Wang Yuanlu, the first ‘curator’ of the Stein Collection’s Dunhuang corpus

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Abstract

Wang Yuanlu 王圓籙, the individual who accidentally stumbled upon the ‘library cave’ or Cave 17 at the Mogao Caves near Dunhuang in June 1900, is behind one of the world’s most significant discoveries. Yet, in the years that followed, he was also responsible for the scattering of the cave’s contents, selling large chunks to Marc Aurel Stein in 1907 and to Paul Pelliot in 1908. How could the self-appointed guardian of this major Buddhist complex part with one of what is often described as its crowning jewels? This article delves into Wang Yuanlu’s motivations and highlights his agency, demonstrating that he was instrumental in shaping the now so-called Stein collection. One of the key sources for this investigation are the published writings of Marc Aurel Stein, which provide the most detailed descriptions of Wang and his activities during the period of the dispersal of the contents of Cave 17. These are supplemented by information drawn from the relevant parts of Stein’s diaries, Paul Pelliot’s writings and primary sources and recent scholarship in Chinese that shed a different light on Wang’s doings. The article starts by studying Wang’s relationship to the Mogao Caves and their wider ecosystem. It then looks at the subsequent dispersal of the newly found hoard through his transactions with Stein in 1907 and 1914, which are contrasted with his dealings with Pelliot.

Introduction

In June 1900, an individual named Wang Yuanlu 王圓籙 (1850?–1931) noticed a crack in the wall of the corridor leading to a large cave, Cave 16, at the Mogao Caves site, near Dunhuang, as he was conducting some restoration work. Upon checking what was behind the exposed plaster, he discovered a door behind which a small chamber had been excavated in the rock.

Now commonly referred to as Cave 17 or the 'library cave', this room is thought to have been sealed off at the beginning of the eleventh century. It turned out to be a real "time capsule of Silk Road history,"[1] containing tens of thousands of manuscripts, as well as printed documents, paintings on paper and silk, textiles and other Buddhist artefacts.

Wang rapidly alerted local officials to this discovery, but no immediate actions were taken. In 1904, orders were sent to keep the collection in place, and he remained *de facto* custodian of the cave. In 1910, an official from the Ministry of Education was dispatched to Dunhuang to transport all the manuscripts left in Cave 17 to Beijing for safekeeping. By then, the British-Hungarian archaeologist Aurel Stein (1862–1943) and the French Sinologist Paul Pelliot (1878–1945) had already respectively visited the Mogao Caves in 1907 and 1908, and Wang had agreed to sell them both exceptionally large chunks of the repository's contents. Later on, he parted with more items against payment. For this reason, Wang Yuanlu has been cast down in Chinese history as a villain, whose name, although associated with the discovery of Cave 17, is even more so linked to the dispersal of its contents. He has often been portrayed as being illiterate and unaware of the significance of the trove held in the cave, which resulted in him being duped by Western explorers. Others have simply considered him to be the prime example of a thief, who profited from the sale of Dunhuang relics.[2] In recent years, several Chinese scholars have started to show that Wang was driven by his piety and desire to protect the Mogao Caves. Yet he remains overall an obscure figure.

[1] Valerie Hansen, *The Silk Road: A New History*, Oxford; New York: Oxford University Press, 2012: pp. 167–97.

[2] Chen Wanli 陳萬里, *Xixing riji* 西行日記 [A Diary of Westward Travels], edited by Yang Xiaobin, Lanzhou: Gansu renmin chubanshe, 2000: p. 8.

Both Marc Aurel Stein's personal narratives, *Ruins of Desert Cathay* and *On central Asian tracks,* and the expedition reports that he wrote, *Serindia* and *Innermost Asia*, provide complementary accounts of his visits to the Mogao Caves and his negotiations with Wang Yuanlu over the contents of Cave 17. These books play a key part in shaping Stein's self-representation, as he glorifies his own actions and, in doing so, minimises Wang's role. However, when reading between the lines and bringing in other contemporary sources, it becomes possible to see Wang Yuanlu having a much more important part in the care, arrangement and dispersal of the cave's contents. While Stein's published accounts had a 'performative' dimension, they also contain information about Wang's custodianship of the caves, his relationship to the wider local community, his motivations for selling Cave 17's contents, and the way he selected materials for the explorer's 'examination'. Therefore, this article critically examines these writings, contrasting them (when relevant) with material from his travel diaries, as well as Pelliot's account and other contemporaneous sources in Chinese. It highlights Wang Yuanlu's agency, demonstrating that he was instrumental in shaping the now so-called Stein collection when it comes to the items removed from Mogao Cave 17. It thus proposes to build a fuller picture of Wang, the "priestly 'librarian"[3] who could be considered as the first 'curator' of the cave's contents.

Abbot Wang: Guardian of the Mogao Caves

Wang Yuanlu and the discovery of Cave 17

[3] M. Aurel Stein, *Ruins of Desert Cathay: Personal narrative of Explorations in Central Asia and Westernmost China*, London: Macmillan, 1912: p. 190.

Little is known about Wang Yuanlu 王圓祿 (figure 1).[4] Much of the information we have about him comes from the accounts of Stein, Pelliot and other foreign explorers.[5] Originally from Macheng 麻城 County in Hubei 湖北, he was born around 1849–1850. Later in life, having fled the drought and famine raging in his native province, he ended up at Jiuquan 酒泉 (then Suzhou 肅州) and served in the military.[6] During his service, Wang Yuanlu converted to Daoism under the guidance of a master named Shengdao 盛道.[7] After being discharged from the army, Wang became a Daoist priest. This earned him the nickname of Wang Daoshi 王道

[4] Several Chinese primary sources dating from the time Wang Yuanlu was active at Dunhuang indicate that his name (though phonetically the same) was originally with the characters '園祿.' It is only on his epitaph that it was changed to '圓籙'. In addition, Fang Guangchang has suggested that his secular name was Wang Fulin 王福琳. Fang Guangchang 方廣錩, "Wang Daoshi mingcheng kao 王道士名称考[On the Name and Titles of Taoist Priest Wang]", Dunhuang yanjiu 敦煌研究 4, 2016, p. 111–118.

[5] Rong Xinjiang, *Eighteen Lectures on Dunhuang*, translated by Imre Galambos, Leiden; Boston: Brill, 2013: 107.

[6] Stein thought that Wang Yuanlu "was a poor friendless mendicant" from Shaanxi 陝西. See M. Aurel Stein, *Serindia: detailed report of explorations in Central Asia and westernmost China, etc.*, Volume 2, Oxford: Clarendon Press, 1921: p. 804. Wang Jiqing examined in detail the various sources available and demonstrated that although Wang Yuanlu's place of origin is most often given as Hubei, including on his epitaph, some official Chinese documents from the late Qing dynasty mention that he came from Hanzhong 漢中 in Shaanxi. According to Wang Jiqing, it is perfectly conceivable that Wang Yuanlu was born in Hubei but spent a lot of his adult life in Shaanxi. Wang Jiqing 王冀青, *Guo bao liu san: Zang jing dong de gu shi* 國寶流散: 藏經洞的故事, Lanzhou: Gansu jiaoyu chubanshe, 2007: pp.3–6.

[7] Rong, *Eighteen Lectures on Dunhuang*, 2013: pp. 79–80.

士 (‘the Daoshi’ for Stein).[8] At the extreme end of the 19th century, possibly between 1897 and 1899, Wang Yuanlu settled at the Mogao Caves complex 莫高窟 or Caves of the Thousand Buddhas 千佛洞, where he stayed until his death in 1931.



Figure 1, portrait of Wang Yuanlu taken by Stein on 11 June 1907, from the collections of The British Library: Photo 392/26(327)

The Mogao caves are located within close distance southeast of the oasis-town of Dunhuang 敦煌, which was established as a frontier garrison outpost in the second century BCE and came to be a strategic spot at the cross of the Northern and the Southern Silk Roads. The first cave is said to have been carved in 366 CE by a Buddhist pilgrim monk and, over the next millennium, almost one thousand caves and niches were gradually excavated in the

[8] The term ‘daoshi 道士’ has often been translated as ‘Abbot’ in English, although it would be more accurate to call him a ‘Priest’ or a ‘Daoist Master’.

sandstone cliff-face, half of them richly decorated with painted murals and clay sculptures. In the fourteenth century, the land Silk Roads began to decline, and the site gradually fell into disuse. When the Frenchman Charles-Eudes Bonin (1865–1929) visited the Mogao Caves in 1899, around the same time Wang Yuanlu himself arrived at the site, he commented on the fact that the caves on the lower level were in danger of being completely silted up if no one took adequate measures.[9] Little did he know that Wang had come to the same realisation.

Soon after settling down at the Mogao Caves, Wang Yuanlu started to collect donations from devout locals. With the money, he set about repairing the three-storey complex linked to the eminent ninth-century Monk Wu Hongbian.[10] By the time Stein arrived at the Mogao Caves, Wang had restored a large Buddhist cave on the ground floor, now known as Cave 16, "to what he conceived to have been its original glory."[11] Wang Yuanlu hired several workers to clear off drift-sand and debris from its entrance. As they were slowly proceeding to their task, they

[9] Charles-Eudes Bonin, "Les grottes des Mille Bouddhas," *Comptes rendus des séances de l'Académie des Inscriptions et Belles-Lettres* 45(2), 1901: p. 212. For a detailed article about Bonin's visit at Dunhuang and relations with explorers Pelliot and Hedin, see Mélodie Doumy, "Charles-Eudes Bonin: the first French Person to visit Dunhuang," *Silk Roads Archaeology and Heritage*, 1(1), 1–20, DOI: https://doi.org/10.5334/srah.3. For a full biography of Bonin in French see Stéphane Malsagne, *Au Coeur du Grand Jeu: La France en Orient. Charles-Eudes Bonin (1865–1929), explorateur diplomate*, Paris: Geuthner, 2015.

[10] This information is found in the stele "Record of Merit for the Restoration of the Thousand Buddha Caves' three-storey building (Ch. "Chong xiu Qianfodong san ceng lou gong de bei ji 重修千佛洞三层楼功德碑记") dated to 1906, as well as in Wang Yuanlu's epitaph. See Fan Guangchun 樊光春, "Dunhuang Daoshi Wang Yuanlu pingzhuan 敦煌道士王圆箓评传 [Critical Biography of Dunhuang's Daoist priest Wang Yuanlu]", *Zhongguo daojiao* 中國道教 5, 2008: p.

[11] Stein, *Ruins of Desert Cathay*, 1912: p. 168.

accidentally stumbled upon a small hidden cave in June 1900.[12] Excavated out in the north wall of the corridor and later closed off, the room was only a few cubic metres large. It was filled, from floor to ceiling, with manuscripts, paintings, textiles and other artefacts. These items dated from the late fourth century to the beginning of the eleventh centuries; the time around which the cave, commonly referred to as Cave 17 or the 'library cave', was probably sealed off.

Perhaps hoping to get some form of financial compensation or recognition for his pious endeavours, Wang Yuanlu immediately went to report the discovery to the local county magistrate Yan Ze 嚴澤 (dates unknown). He took two manuscripts with him as proof, but no actions were taken. When the new county magistrate, Wang Zonghan 汪宗翰 (b. 1845), came to Dunhuang in April 1902, he was informed of the existence of Cave 17 and given several of its items. In turn, Wang Zonghan wrote about this to the epigrapher Ye Changshi 葉昌熾 (1849–1917), who was Gansu provincial education commissioner from 1902 to 1906.[13] Furthermore, it appears that Wang also showed a case of manuscripts to the Qing official Ting Dong 廷棟 (1866–1918), but the latter did not regard these as important.[14] Based on Stein's

[12] The date of the discovery of Cave 17 varies depending on sources: it can be given as 20, 22 or 25 June 1907.

[13] Huang Zheng 黃征, *Jie chen yi zhu: Dunhuang yi shu* 劫尘遗珠: 敦煌遗书 [The Lost Pearl: Dunhuang Manuscripts], Lanzhou: Gansu jiaoyu chubanshe, 1999: pp. 10–13. Rong Xinjiang and Justin Jacobs both suggested that Wang Yuanlu may not have told Wang Zonghan and local authorities the whole truth about the actual scope of the cave's contents. They refer to the fact that Ye Changchi 葉昌熾 (1849–1917), Gansu provincial education commissioner from 1902 to 1906, thought that the cave only had several hundreds of manuscripts. It could be that he heard this from Wang Zonghan, who was deliberately misled by Wang Yuanlu. See Rong, *Eighteen Lectures on Dunhuang*, 2013: pp. 90–1; p. 101; Justin Jacobs, *The Compensations of Plunder: How China Lost its Treasures*, Chicago; London: The University of Chicago Press, 2020: pp. 96–7.

[14] Rong, *Eighteen Lectures on Dunhuang*, 2013: pp. 85.

expedition report, "news of the discovery having reached distant Lanzhou, specimens of the manuscripts were asked for from provincial headquarters."[15] These manuscripts were thought to be Chinese Buddhist scrolls.[16] However, "hours of diplomatic converse" with Wang Yuanlu purportedly revealed to the explorer that "they had failed to attract any interest there" and that:

> […] to Wang's undisguised chagrin no further notice had been taken of his treasured old manuscripts or, indeed, of his pious labours which had led to their discovery. Officialdom had rested satisfied with a rough statement that the whole of the manuscripts would make up seven cartloads, and, evidently grudging the cost of transport or the trouble of close examination, had left the whole undisturbed in charge of the Tao-shih [Daoshi] as self-constituted guardian of the temple.[17]

In any event, in May 1904, the provincial government ordered Wang Zonghan in Dunhuang to take measures for the preservation of Cave 17's contents.[18] Some scholars have argued that he was also asked to take an inventory of the manuscripts and paintings.[19] As for

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[15] Stein, *Serindia*, 1921: p. 802.

[16] Stein, *Serindia*, 1921: p. 803.

[17] Stein, *Serindia*, 1921: 803–4; see also Stein, *Ruins of Desert Cathay*, 167 and Wang Jiqing, "Aurel Stein's Dealings with Wang Yuanlu and Chinese Officials in Dunhuang in 1907", in Helen Wang (ed.) *Sir Aurel Stein, Colleagues and Collections*, London: British Museum Publications, 2012: p. 3. For an expanded version of this article see Wang Jiqing 王冀青, "1907 nian Sitanyin yu Wang yuanlu ji Dunhuang guanyuan zhijian de jiaozhu 1907 年斯坦因与王圆禄及敦煌官员之间的交往 [Stein's dealings with Wang Yuanlu and Dunhuang officials in 1907]", *Dunhuang xue jikan* 3, 2007: pp. 60–76.

[18] Huang Zheng, *Jie chen yi zhu*, 1999: pp. 10–13. See also Wang Jiqing, "Aurel Stein's Dealings with Wang Yuanlu", 2012: p. 3.

[19] Ma Shichang 马世长 used the colophon written by Wang Zonghan on a painting from Cave 17 as proof. The dedication, which has been translated into English with the help of Hsieh Han-Lin, reads as follows:

> 甘肅敦煌縣千佛洞宋初石室所藏畫大士像。光緒卅年四月朔, 奉檄檢點經卷畫像， 迎歸署中供養。 信士敦煌知縣王宗翰謹記。

Wang Yuanlu, to whom the overall responsibility of safeguarding the deposit was delegated, he had to restore the whole of the find to its original place. We do not know if the task of undertaking an inventory befell him too, but there is evidence that he took necessary precautions to prevent anyone from entering the cave without his consent. In his travel diary, Stein recounts that he first heard of the manuscripts found at the Mogao Caves from Zahid Beg, a trader from Urumchi, who told him that these "had been locked by order."[20] Indeed, Wang had attached a wooden door to the opening of the cave and kept the key. On 16 March 1907, when Stein and his Chinese secretary Jiang Xiaowan 蔣孝琬 or Jiang Shiye 蔣師爺[21] (d.1922) first came to the Mogao caves and tried to access the small cave, it was carefully locked in the absence of Wang Yuanlu, who had gone begging for alms around Dunhuang with two followers.[22] Upon returning two months later, on 21 May 1907, the British-Hungarian explorer found out that the narrow opening had been "completely walled up with brickwork," allegedly to protect it from the intrusion of eager pilgrims.[23] When the French sinologist Paul Pelliot

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Tang dynasty painting of Avalokiteśvara stored in an early Song dynasty cave at the Thousand Buddha Caves in Dunhuang county, Gansu. On the first day of the 4th moon of the 30th year of Guangxu, I took the official order to inventory the sutra scrolls and paintings and to bring them back to the government for offering. Recorded by the devotee Wang Zonghan, magistrate of Dunhuang.

See Ma Shichang, "Guanyu Dunhuang Cangjingdong de ji ge wenti 关于敦煌藏经洞的几个问题 [Several questions regarding Dunhuang Cave 17]," *Wenwu* 12 (1978): p. 22; p. 33 n.3.

[20] The Bodleian Libraries Oxford, typed transcript of Stein's field diaries from December 1906 to August 1908, entry for 15 March 1907, MSS Stein 245: f. 167.

[21] The term 'shiye 師爺' refers to Jiang's role as a private assistant or private advisor, attending to secretarial duties for Stein.

[22] Stein, *Ruins of Desert Cathay*, 1912: p. 29.

[23] Stein, *Ruins of Desert Cathay*, 1912: pp. 165–6.

went to the Mogao Caves in 1908, the door to Cave 17 was locked and he had to wait for Wang Yuanlu to meet him with the key.[24]

We have therefore seen that Wang, who was already acting as the self-appointed caretaker of the Mogao Caves, came to oversee the protection Cave 17 and its contents in a semi-official capacity in the years following his extraordinary chance discovery. Having attempted to alert several officials, he was instructed to provisionally look after the small cave and its contents, and locked it for safety. We will now demonstrate that he was not assuming this role as a lone Daoist monk but rather as a well-integrated member of the local religious community, including resident Buddhist monks.

Wang Yuanlu and the local Buddhist Community

In 1894, the Russian officer and explorer Vsevolod Ivanovich Roborovsky (1856–1910) visited Dunhuang and noted that the Thousand Buddha Caves still attracted up to 10,000 worshippers every year.[25] Over a decade later, the annual celebrations Stein witnessed on his way back from the Dunhuang Limes demonstrated that the Caves, "notwithstanding all

[24] Paul Pelliot, "Une bibliothèque médiévale retrouvée au Kan-sou", *Bulletin de l'École Française d'Extrême Orient* 8 (1908): p. 505; this was also mentioned in his travel diary on 27 February 1908. See Pelliot, *Carnets de Route, 1906-1908*, edited by Jérôme Ghesquière and Francis Macouin, Paris: Les Indes savantes, Musée national des arts asiatiques-Guimet, 2008: p. 277.

[25] Irina Popova, "S.F. Oldenburg's Second Russian Turkestan Expedition (1914–1915)", in *Russian Expeditions to Central Asia at the Turn of the 20th Century*, St. Petersburg: Slavia, 2008: p. 163; http://www.orientalstudies.ru/rus/images/pdf/a_popova_2008d.pdf.

apparent decay, were still real cult places 'in being'." A few Buddhist dwellers also resided at the site. When Wang Yuanlu first put down roots at the Mogao Caves, three temples were located in front of the caves: the upper and middle temples were already occupied by Tibetan monks, so he moved to the lower temple in the southern section of the site.[26] Wang Jiqing has suggested that the lower temple was used for Daoist activities in the early 1820s, but that it later went unoccupied for a long time.[27] It would be misleading to think that there was no interaction between Wang and these local Buddhist monks. In 1907, Stein observed that Wang lived with two "humble acolytes," likely the same two companions who went with him on begging tours, and that he appeared to "spen[d] next to nothing on his person or private interests," channelling all the donations collected over the years "upon [these] labours of piety."[28] The perception that Wang was dedicated and selflessness was also confirmed in the 1980s by a member of the Dunhuang Academy, Li Zhengyu 李正宇, who had derived the same information from local stories.[29]

[26] The Bodleian Libraries Oxford, typed transcript of Stein's field diaries, entry for 27 May 1907, MSS Stein 204: ff. 315. See also Rong, 2013: 82; Justin Jacobs, *The Compensations of Plunder: How China Lost its Treasures*, Chicago; London: The University of Chicago Press, 2020: p. 95.

[27] According to Wang Jiqing, Gusztáv von Kreitner (1847–1893), who visited the site in May 1879 with the Count Béla Széchenyi (1837–1893) and Lajos Lóczy (1849–1920), referred to two lamas, established already for 15 years at the Mogao Caves in his travel account, but he did not allude to the presence of any Daoist monks. Neither did the Russian explorer Nikolai Mikhailovich Przhevalsky (1839–1888) who came to Dunhuang a few months later. See Wang, *Guo bao liu san*, 2007: p. 8.

[28] Stein, *Ruins of Desert Cathay*, 1912: p. 168.

[29] Jin Ronghua 金榮華, Wang Daoshi – Dunhuang wenwu wailiu guanjian renwu tanwu 王道士 – 敦煌文物外流關鍵人物探微[The Daoist Priest Wang – Exploring the key figures in the dispersal of Dunhuang items], Taipei: Xinwen feng chuban gufen youxian gongsi, 1993: p.109.

Wang Yuanlu was continuing or joining efforts to rehabilitate the site that had started before his arrival.[30] As explained by the Russian army officer Vsevolod Ivanovich Roborovsky, limited repairs were already underway when he visited the Mogao Caves in 1894:

> The *heshang* 和尚 [monks] living there (4 people) complain that the government is taking no measures to repair the caves, whereas private donations for the purpose are scarce. So far only 5 or 6 caves have been put right; entrances to them have been mended, wooden annexes built and *fanzas* for *heshang* repaired.[31]

In some of his correspondence, Stein referred to Wang Yuanlu as "the priest chiefly concerned" with Cave 17,[32] which makes sense given the specific role he was entrusted with. His published narrative conveys the impression that Wang carried this responsibility with the support of resident Buddhist monks, who oversaw the care of the Caves with him:

> The shrine, though full of Buddhist frescoes and sculptures, was in charge of a Taoist priest, the small fraternity of Ho-shangs [he shang 和尚] or Buddhist monks, to which our guide belonged, peacefully sharing with him the guardianship of the site.[33]

[30] As early as 1772, a lama named Li Xinneng 李心能 and his disciple Yuan Xiu 源修 undertook to restore the Leiyin Temple 雷音寺 with the alms they had collected. See Wang, *Guo bao liu san*, 2007: p. 7.

[31] The text was translated and quoted by Irina Popova from Труды экспедиции ИРГО по Центральной Азии. Ч. 1. Отчет начальника экспедиции В.И. Роборовского [*Works of the IRGS Expedition to Central Asia. Part 1. Report of the Expedition Head V.I. Roborovsky*]. St Petersburg, 1900: 218. See Popova, "S.F. Oldenburg's Second Russian Turkestan Expedition (1914–1915)", 2008: p. 163.

[32] Confidential report by Stein concerning the cache of ancient manuscripts at Dunhuang, British Museum Central Archives, CE 32/23/16/2.

[33] Stein, *Ruins of Desert Cathay*, 1912: p. 29.

From this description, we gain a picture of Wang Yuanlu not only living alongside local Buddhist monks, but also collaborating with them towards the same ends.

There is evidence that Wang granted them access to some of the items from Cave 17. As mentioned earlier, Stein had to wait before he could access the "walled up library" and take full measure of its treasures because Wang was not there when he first made his way to the Mogao Caves. In *Serindia*, Stein wrote that a young monk helped him and Jiang Xiaowan to locate the newly discovered hoard and agreed to show them one of the Chinese scrolls from Cave 17. The "beautifully preserved" manuscript, "with its fine texture and carefully smoothed surface," showed "excellent penmanship" and had been lent to his spiritual master, a Tibetan lama, in order to give "additional lustre" to his small private chapel.[34] Stein noted in his diaries that the specimen was brought by Jiang from the chapel of an absent monk and that a young monk acted as a guide—an account that appears to align with his published narrative.[35] A photograph taken in 1908 by Charles Nouette, the photographer of the expedition led by Paul Pelliot, also depicts a Buddhist monk engaged in ritual practice (figure 2). He is standing before an altar on which he has set up a book, an incense burner, several statues, and a few other ritual objects. We can see several paintings hanging in the background, two of which are now in the collections of the Musée Guimet in France.[36] If these paintings indeed came from Cave 17, this

[34] Stein, *Serindia*, 1921: pp. 801–2.

[35] Bodleian Libraries Oxford, typed transcript of Stein's field diaries from December 1906 to August 1908, entry for 16 March 1907, MSS Stein 204: f. 169.

[36] The silk paintings are EO 3579, which represents the Amoghapaśa mandala, and EO 1146, which is probably the remaining top section of a mandala. I am very grateful to Roderick Whitfield, who helped with this identification, personal communication 14 December 2023.

suggests again that local Buddhist monks used some of the cave's contents for religious purposes, presumably with Wang's consent.[37]



Figure 2, 'Monk celebrating his ecclesiastical office at Qianfodong', photograph taken by Charles Nouette between 25 February and 27 May 1908, (c)MNAAG, Paris, Dist. RMN-Grand Palais / image musée Guimet: AP8586

That such a significant Buddhist complex, even one that had fallen into dereliction and relative disuse, ended up being overseen by a Daoist monk may seem surprising. One should remember that there probably was no real clear-cut divide between Daoism and Buddhism at the time. For instance, Stein remarked that the peoples of Dunhuang were "attached with particular zeal to such forms of worship as represent Buddhism in the queer

[37] This implies that it would probably have been difficult for Wang Yuanlu to sell these specific items to Pelliot without some level of awareness among the resident monks.

medley of Chinese popular religion."[38] Whether Wang Yuanlu was truly Daoist has been debated. For instance, László Bárdi highlighted that Wang was cited in alternative fashion as a Daoist or a Buddhist, and that some sources indicate he changed status over time, from a Daoist to a Buddhist monk.[39] It is not uncommon for Daoist practitioners to also venerate Buddhist deities, such as Guanyin.

In fact, Wang Yuanlu was most probably initiated to the Longmen branch of Quanzhen Daoism, which was present at Dunhuang then and remains one of the largest Daoist sects in China today.[40] Scholars have stressed that this particular branch of Daoism includes many elements that are indistinguishable from Buddhism.[41] According to Rong Xinjiang, the aim of Wang's restorations was to convert Buddhist halls into Daoist shrines.[42] While Stein's accounts referred to Wang's works as "tokens of lingering Buddhist worship, genuine though distorted,"[43] his travel diary did mention an "invasion of Taoist imagery" in the shrines.[44] Wang's epitaph, inscribed on the tomb stone erected by two of his disciples in 1931, states that he was put in charge of the county's Daoist Association by the magistrate Lu Qian 陸前

[38] Stein, *On Ancient Central-Asian Tracks: Brief Narrative of Three Expeditions in Innermost Asia and North-Western China*, Volume 1, London: Macmillan & Co., 1933: p. 199.

[39] László Bárdi, "Chinese Assessment of Sir Aurel M. Stein's Work," in István Erdélyi (ed.), *Aurel Stein Bibliography*, Bloomington, Ind.: Eurolingua, 1999: p. 45, n.1.

[40] Fan Guangchun 樊光春, "Dunhuang Daoshi Wang Yuanlu pingzhuan 敦煌道士王圓箓评传 [Critical Biography of Dunhuang's Daoist priest Wang Yuanlu]", *Zhongguo daojiao* 中國道教 5, 2008: p.

[41] John Abercombie, "Syncretism in the study of Quanzhen Taoism: from essence to argument", PhD thesis, Whitman College, 2012, last accessed 18/07/2024 arminda.whitman.edu/theses/12.

[42] Rong, *Eighteen Lectures on Dunhuang*, 2013: p. 83.

[43] Stein, *Ruins of Desert Cathay*, 1912: p. 169.

[44] Bodleian Libraries Oxford, entry for 29 May 2023, MSS Stein 204: f. 320.

in recognition of his merits. Importantly, the epitaph stresses Wang's genuine dedication to restoring the Mogao Caves, including the Buddhist statues, as well as his endeavour to convince people of contributing money towards these efforts.[45] As attested by a letter on red paper signed in his name, it seems that Wang Yuanlu even sent a plea for a large donation to the local administration, following the transfer of Cave 17's remaining contents to Beijing.[46]

It is therefore clear that being a Daoist did not preclude Wang from revering the Mogao Caves as a Buddhist site and devoting his existence to their upkeep. According to the stele "Record of the Thousand Buddha Caves' Thousand Images Pagoda" by Ting Dong, Wang Yuanlu collected several damaged Buddha statues in 1910 and placed them in a specially built pagoda.[47] The pagoda was demolished in the 1940s and the artefacts it

[45] The tomb stone is located inside a stupa containing the remains of Wang Yuanlu, near the Mogao Caves. Zhao Mingyu 趙明玉, "Tai qing gong da fang zhang dao hui si Wang shi Fazhen muzhi 太清宮大方丈道會司王師法真墓誌," in Wei Juxian, *Dunhuang shishi* (1946): pp. 35–6.

[46] The letter is held at the Dunhuang Academy, under the object number D0311. Referred to in Chinese as '催養經款草丹' or '王道士薦疏' it is signed by Wang Yuanlu and dated to the first to third years of the Xuantong 宣统 reign (1910 to 1911). Some scholars have also suggested that the letter was addressed to the Empress Cixi 慈禧 or to an eminent Buddhist monk. I am grateful to Dunhuang Academy colleagues for this information and for showing me the document.

[47] This information is recorded in the stele "Record of the Thousand Buddha Caves' Thousand Images Pagoda" (Ch. "Dunhuang Qianfodong Xiangta ji 敦煌千佛洞千相塔记"), dated to the second year of Xuantong's reign. See Fan Guangchun, "Dunhuang Daoshi Wang Yuanlu pingzhuan", 2008: p. The stele, 112 centimetres high by 56 centimetres wide and 12 centimetres thick, is now in the exhibition centre of the Dunhuang Academy (collection number is Z1114).

contained are now in the collections of the Dunhuang Academy.[48] There is further evidence that Wang Yuanlu's worship extended to the contents of Cave 17, in particular textual materials. We know of two instances when he directly used the manuscripts from the cave for devotional and merit-making purposes. A document in the Dunhuang county archives dated to 1910 recorded that, in 1908, he "loaded some Buddhist scrolls into two barrel-like containers, tightly sealed these and placed them on wooden poles inside a Buddhist hall, calling them sūtra-turning wheels."[49] In 1944, the Dunhuang Academy also found 72 manuscripts inside a statue located in a Daoist temple built by Wang Yuanlu in the early 1900s.[50] Given the public and communal nature of these activities it is highly likely that members of the resident Buddhist community knew of them.

We can now see that Wang Yuanlu, who made it his mission in life to raise funds towards the upkeep and restoration of the Mogao Caves, joined ongoing initiatives that had begun long before his arrival and was deeply connected to the site's Buddhist monks. Upon finding Cave 17, he became responsible for safeguarding its contents, albeit as a representative of the local religious community at large. Both Wang and the resident monks established at the caves were using some of the cave's manuscripts and paintings for their ritual activities. Such

[48] Zhao Shengliang 赵声良, "1943 nian Luo Jimei pai she Dunhuang shi ku zhao pian de yi yi 1943 年罗寄梅拍摄敦煌石窟照片的意义 [The significance of Luo Jimei's 1943 photographs of the Dunhuang Caves", in Pengpai Xinwen 澎湃新闻, 23 October 2019, https://www.thepaper.cn/newsDetail_forward_4633619 (last accessed on 03 April 2024).

[49] Rong Xinjiang, *Eighteen Lectures on Dunhuang*, 2013: pp. 116–7.

[50] Jean-Pierre Drège, "Notes codicologiques sur les manuscrits de Dunhuang et de Turfan", *Bulletin de l'Ecole française d'Extrême Orient* 74 (1985): p. 489.

information calls for a deeper foray into Wang's relation to the contents of the small repository.

Wang Yuanlu and the contents of Cave 17

Contrary to what has been said, Wang Yuanlu was not illiterate. He possessed at least some rudimentary literacy and numeracy skills, as demonstrated by the fact he kept a list of the various donations he received.[51] The letter on red paper mentioned earlier in this article could have been written by Wang, even if it is unconfirmed. Furthermore, a Dunhuang manuscript in Ryukoku University's Omiya Collection bears two inscriptions that have been tentatively attributed to him by the scholar Fang Guangchang, which could be evidence of his ability to write Chinese.[52] Stein's assistant, Jiang Xiaowan, reported that Wang was "ignorant of all that constitutes traditional Chinese scholarship".[53] Ironically, the two of them were ill-placed to make this observation: Stein deplored "the great hindrance created by [his] total want of

[51] Wang Yuanlu showed his accounts and his temple subscription to Jiang Xiaowan. See Stein, *Ruins of Desert Cathay*, 1912: p. 168. When Stein went back to the Mogao Caves in 1914, Wang still kept a "fine red book of donations". See *Innermost Asia: Detailed Report of Explorations in Central Asia, Kan-su and Eastern Iran*, Oxford: Clarendon Press, 1928: p. 357.

[52] Fang Guangchang 方廣錩, "Wang Daoshi mingcheng kao 王道士名称考[On the Name and Titles of Taoist Priest Wang]", *Dunhuang yanjiu* 敦煌研究 4, 2016, p. 116–118.

[53] Stein, *Serindia*, 1921: p. 804.

Sinological training" when faced with the mass of Chinese rolls from Cave 17,[54] while Jiang struggled to make sense of their Buddhist content.[55]

With the help of his local network, Wang Yuanlu might have had an edge over them in identifying some of the texts from the small cave. During his visit in 1908, the French sinologist Paul Pelliot observed perfectly ordered Tibetan manuscripts enclosed in wooden covers. Relying on information from some Tibetan monks, Wang identified them as a form of Kanjur, which Pelliot interpreted as an early version of the Tibetan Buddhist canon:

> It seemed probable *a priori* that the perfectly ordered kia-pan, the only works in order in the whole library, represented a Kandjur; and this is precisely the information that the Wang tao gave me himself, based on the testimony of the lamas who have had access to the cave.[56]

While this turned out not to be strictly true, since the volumes contained copies of *Perfection of Wisdom* sutras, the lamas were perhaps identifying the volumes as 'Kanjur' because of their appearance and because they contained important canonical texts. Such large volumes could have served a similar ritual function to Kanjur collections in local monasteries. In any case, this indicates that Wang was able to gather valuable knowledge through local sources.

There is further reason to believe that Wang Yuanlu's limited knowledge was sufficient for him to realise the importance of the manuscripts, paintings and other relics that

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[54] Stein, *Serindia*, 1921: p. 821; p. 809: "The limitations of my philological knowledge would not permit a rapid selection of what might be of special interest amidst these masses of Chinese texts."

[55] Stein, *Serindia*, 1921: p. 802.

[56] Paul Pelliot, "Une grotte médiévale retrouvée au Kan-sou", *Bulletin de l'École française d'Extrême-Orient* 8 (1908): p. 507.: "Il semblait probable *a priori* que les kia-pan parfaitement en ordre, les seuls ouvrages en ordre de toute la bibliothèque, représentaient un Kandjur; et c'est justement le renseignement que m'a donné de lui-même le Wang tao, sur la foi des lamas qui ont eu accès dans la grotte."

the cave contained. On numerous occasions, including some mentioned earlier, Wang gave away discreet batches from the newly found hoard to officials and dignitaries in Gansu, causing the early dispersal of Cave 17's contents from 1900 onwards.[57] In doing so, Wang was perfectly able to select the better preserved, most complete and aesthetically pleasing specimens. He handpicked several beautiful paintings and removed Buddhist and Daoist scriptures that were not only finely written but also happened to possess a high scholarly value.[58] Pelliot's writings also reveal that there were copper statuettes in the cave, which Wang Yuanlu also used as gifts.[59] As stressed by Susan Whitfield, to find such exceptional specimens, Wang Yuanlu would have gone through a considerable number of items.[60]

At some point between 1900 and 1904, Wang completely emptied Cave 17 before he received the order to put the whole 'collection' back in it.[61] During this process, he must have had the opportunity to form an overall idea of everything that had been deposited in the small room prior to its sealing off. Because the scattering of the cave's contents started very soon after its discovery, this makes Wang Yuanlu the only person who was ever close to knowing their full extent and original arrangement. Stein wrote that Wang was looking for "valuables".[62] This somehow conveyed the image of Wang Yuanlu as an individual driven by greed. It would

[57] Hundreds of items – both manuscripts and paintings – had been given to officials and other individuals before Aurel Stein arrived at Dunhuang in 1907. See Rong Xinjiang, 2013: pp. 84–102.

[58] Rong Xinjiang, 2013: p. 84; pp. 100–1.

[59] These items proved particularly popular and were rapidly almost exhausted, but Pelliot managed to secure a few during his visit. See Pelliot, "Une grotte médiévale retrouvée au Kan-sou", (1908): p. 506; p. 528.

[60] Paschalia Terzi and Susan Whifield, "Reconstructing a Medieval Library? The Contents of the Manuscript Bundles in the Dunhuang Library Cave", *Silk Roads Archaeology and Heritage* 1(1) (2023): pp. 56–76.

[61] Stein, *Ruins of Desert Cathay*, 1912: p. 182; *Serindia*, 1921: pp. 808–9.

[62] Stein, *Ruins of Desert Cathay*, 1912: p. 182; *Serindia*, 1921: pp. 808–9.

be more accurate and fairer to say that he was searching for valuable items, which could be understood in terms of their significance as well as their monetary value. Wasn't the British-Hungarian explorer himself drawn to the Caves of the Thousand Buddhas by the promise of Cave 17's hidden "treasures"? [63] Wang could have decanted the cave to get a better understanding of what was in there, perhaps even to re-order its contents in an arrangement that he deemed more adequate.

Wang Yuanlu certainly did play a vital role in the organisation of Cave 17's contents when he rehoused them. Stein described what were two very distinct kinds of bundles in the cave: the 'regular' bundles, composed of uniform packets containing canonical Buddhist texts in Chinese and Tibetan that may have once belonged to monastic libraries; and the 'miscellaneous' or 'mixed' bundles, filled with fragmentary Chinese and Tibetan rolls, non-Chinese texts, paintings, textiles and other ex-votos.[64] Wang had sorted and structured these bundles according to their type and physical characteristics. At the bottom, he had put several 'miscellaneous' bundles to "what he thought appropriate use in turning the floor at the foot of the north wall and on either side of the clay platform into a foundation level with the latter."[65] In his diary, Stein recorded that some of these bundles, which contained pictures and waste paper, may even have been placed there to keep off the damp.[66] He had then built on them a "wall-like array" of 'regular' manuscript bundles on top of which were placed many more of

[63] Stein, *Serindia*, 1921: p. 801.

[64] Stein, *Serindia*, 1921: p. 814.

[65] Stein, *Serindia*, 1921: p. 823.

[66] Bodleian Libraries Oxford, entry for 28 May 1907, MSS Stein 204: f. 317–8: "During the Tao-shih [Daoshi]'s absence, I succeeded in digging down to floor in the NE corner. Here between the wall & base three bundles full of silk pict[ure]s, waste paper, etc., had been thrown down to keep off the damp! […] No moisture in rock, but clay built base appar[ently] absorbs some from outside air."

the irregularly shaped bundles with heterogeneous contents.[67] If anything, the way Wang rehoused the materials in the cave seemed careful and intentional, not haphazard.[68]

Whether to raise awareness of the pious efforts that were being carried out and solicit donations or to genuinely alert people to this extraordinary discovery, Wang Yuanlu handpicked hundreds of fine manuscripts, paintings and other artefacts and gifted them to officials, triggering their slow dispersal as early as 1900. He may not have realised the full historical, cultural and scholarly value of the objects contained in the hoard, but this is not to say that he did not consider them to be important. Wang knew better than anyone what was inside Cave 17 and carefully re-organised the bundles in a way that reflected, as we will see below, his very own appraisal of the newly found repository's collection.

Wang Yuanlu: Disperser of Cave 17's contents

Aurel Stein's first Visit to Dunhuang

Aurel Stein first visited Dunhuang and the Mogao Caves Buddhist complex during his second Central Asian expedition (1906–1908). The selection and acquisition of paintings, manuscripts and other sacred relics from the cave turned out to be a gradual negotiation process, dependent

[67] Stein, *Serindia*, 1921: p. 814.

[68] When Stein started looking at some of the 'miscellaneous' packets placed at the bottom of the 'regular' bundles, Wang was visibly annoyed that he disturbed his arrangement and proceeded to fill the space with bundles that the explorer had already sifted through. See Bodleian Libraries Oxford, MSS 204: f. 318.

in a large part on the goodwill of Wang Yuanlu. In the words of the British-Hungarian explorer: "We never knew how long we might rely on the Tao-shih [Daoshi]'s indulgence."[69] His writings reveal that the latter played a crucial role from the onset, determining to a large extent what Stein was eventually able to purchase. The whole transaction can be broken down in two distinct phases: the first phase unfolded between 22 May and 6 June 1907; while the second phase took place around October of the same year.[70] We will now explore the way(s) in which Stein dealt with Wang Yuanlu through the intermediary of Jiang Xiaowan on each of these occasions.

As mentioned above, Aurel Stein did not have any direct exchange with Wang Yuanlu when he and Jiang first came to the Caves of the Thousand Buddhas in March 1907. However, they were shadowed by a young monk who revealed the location of Cave 17 and let them examine one of the manuscripts that had been lent to his master. Given how embedded Wang was in the small Buddhist monastic community living at the site, he would most probably have been told about the explorer's visit. Moreover, as Stein waited in town for the local festival and the annual pilgrimage to the Caves to be over, Jiang contacted Wang and asked him to wait for them at the site.[71] Therefore, when Stein returned to the Mogao Caves on 21 May of the same year, Wang Yuanlu immediately came to "welcome [him] at what for most of the year he might well claim as sacred ground entrusted to his own exclusive care."[72]

[69] Stein, *Ruins of Desert Cathay*, 1912: vol.II, p. 188.

[70] For a thorough review of Stein's acquisitions of Dunhuang materials see Terzi and Whitfield, "Reconstructing the Library Cave?", *Silk Roads Archaeology and Heritage* 1(1) (2023): pp. 56–76.

[71] Stein, *Serindia*, 1921: p. 802.

[72] Stein, *Serindia*, 1921: p. 803.

Stein's first description of Wang was particularly unflattering, conveying the image of a shifty-looking, deceitful and untrustworthy individual:

> He looked a very queer person, extremely shy and nervous, with an occasional expression of cunning which was far from encouraging. It was clear from the first that he would be a difficult person to handle.[73]

This is somewhat hypocritical as the explorer himself proudly reported, in the same publication, how he was using subterfuge. The next morning, on 22 May 1907, he deliberately "avoided any long interview" with Wang and pretended to be absorbed by "the survey of the main grottoes, and the photographing of the more notable frescoes."[74] In his published accounts, Stein presented himself as seeking to disguise the main objective of his visit: "[securing] access to the Tao-shih [Daoshi]'s jealously guarded treasures."[75] Even though the scroll the young monk had shown him indicated that the hoard was almost certainly Buddhist and dated to an early period, Stein was yet to "ascertain the true character and approximate date of the collection."[76] Therefore, he first undertook to convince Wang Yuanlu to let him see the manuscripts and paintings in their original place of deposit. We learn from his diaries that, in the afternoon of the same day, he dispatched his secretary Jiang Xiaowan to speak to Wang:

> Sent Sieh [Shiye] during morning to sound [D]aoshi about MSS., wishing to prepare ground slowly. Priest ready to show collection, & before evening S.[hiye] saw it, a large recess crammed full with MSS. to roof![77]

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[73] Stein, *Ruins of Desert Cathay*, 1912: p. 165.

[74] Stein, *Ruins of Desert Cathay*, 1912: p. 165.

[75] Stein, *Serindia*, 1921: p. 802.

[76] Stein, *Ruins of Desert Cathay*, 1912: p. 166.

[77] The Bodleian Libraries Oxford, typed transcript of Stein's field diaries from December 1906 to August 1908, entry for 22 May 1907, MSS Stein 204: f. 305.

This initial conversation was not the open sesame they had hoped for. Wang Yuanlu proved cautious and only consented, "with various meticulous reservations," to let Stein see "such specimens of the collection as he might conveniently lay his hands on."[78] Jiang reported that the mere suggestion that Stein may wish to acquire a few manuscripts, even caused him "manifestly genuine perturbation."[79] Concerned that the promise of money might not suffice to overcome the religious scruples and fear of popular resentment that he believed were behind Wang Yuanlu's reluctance, the explorer decided to pay him a formal visit.[80] He asked to see the restored Cave 16, which he knew to be Wang's "chief care,"[81] as well as "the pride and the mainstay of his [Dunhuang] existence."[82] In one of best-known episodes from his published accounts, which does not appear in his diaries,[83] Stein sought to further gain his trust by invoking the seventh-century Chinese Buddhist monk Xuanzang 玄奘:

> More than once before, my well-known attachment to the memory of Hsuan-tsang, the greatest of those pilgrims, had been helpful in securing me a sympathetic hearing both among the learned and the simple. Wang Tao-shih [Daoshi], too, had probably heard about it. [...] I thought it appropriate to tell Wang Tao-shih [Daoshi], as well as my poor Chinese would permit, of my devotion to the saintly traveller; how I had followed his footsteps from India for over ten thousand Li across inhospitable mountains and deserts; how in the course of the pilgrimage I

[78] Stein, *Ruins of Desert Cathay*, 1912: p. 166.

[79] Stein, *Serindia*, 1921: p. 803.

[80] Stein, *Serindia*, 1921: p. 804; p. 808.

[81] Stein, Serindia, 1921: p. 804.

[82] Stein, *Ruins of Desert Cathay*, 1912: p. 167.

[83] The Bodleian Libraries Oxford, typed transcript of Stein's field diaries from December 1906 to August 1908, entry for 22 May 1907, MSS Stein 204: f. 305–306.

had traced to its present ruins, however inaccessible, many a sanctuary he had previously visited and described; and so on.[84]

Late that night, Jiang came to Stein's tent bearing a "small bundle of manuscript rolls", which Wang had given to him in secret.[85] It must have belonged to the 'regular' bundles, for it contained several Chinese sutras "all neatly rolled up and enclosed in cotton wrappers."[86] It contained several Buddhist scrolls in Chinese, with a note at the commencement stating that they had been first brought from India and translated by Xuanzang 玄奘, the monk Stein claimed as his "Chinese patron saint." Both Stein and Jiang Xiaowan assumed that this auspicious sign could only be a pure coincidence, given that "Wang Tao-shih [Daoshi] in his ignorance could have had no inkling, when he picked up those specimens, of their connexion with [Xuanzang]'s sacred memory."[87] Was it just a lucky accident? It is unlikely: these fine manuscripts would have probably come from the 'regular' bundles filled with canonical texts, so Wang would have had to specifically extract them. If the conversation about Xuanzang did take place that very afternoon, it is certainly worth considering whether Wang was using these scrolls as 'bait' to start the negotiations with Stein.

The following day, on 23 May 1907, Wang Yuanlu removed the brickwork blocking the entrance of Cave 17 and finally opened the door to the cache, which Stein depicted as a "black hole" where "no examination of the manuscripts would be possible."[88] It was agreed that Wang Yuanlu would continue to take out a bundle or two at a time and would let them

[84] Stein, ibid.: p. 169.

[85] Stein, *Serindia*, 1921: p. 807.

[86] The Bodleian Libraries Oxford, typed transcript of Stein's field diaries, entry for 23 May 1907, MSS Stein 204: f. 307.

[87] Stein, *Serindia*, 1921: p. 807.

[88] Stein, *Ruins of Desert Cathay*, 1912: p. 172; *On Ancient central-Asian tracks*, 1933: p. 204.

"look rapidly through their contents in a less cramped and dark part of the temple precincts."[89] A small room located in the antechapel of Cave 16 and sheltered from view was turned into an improvised 'reading room' for Stein and Jiang, who had to proceed fast, for fear that Wang might change his mind.[90] In charge of retrieving items from Cave 17, Wang Yuanlu began by presenting one of the 'miscellaneous' bundles that he had put on top of the 'regular' bundles due to their irregular shape when refilling the cave.[91] Stein thus looked through a "large bundle of silk and cotton banners and prayer flags", two Chinese bundles, "a large convolute of mixed papers," and "one packet of large C[entral] A[sian] sheets.[92]

Stein remarked that "it was mere chance, too, what bundles the Tao-shih [Daoshi] would hand [them] out."[93] It might have looked fortuitous to him, but not to Wang, who planned what to deliver and focused on the items he held in the lowest estimation. The position of the 'miscellaneous' bundles, of course, made them easy to reach, but more importantly this was also a deliberate choice, as Stein's own account shows. While Wang Yuanlu had no qualms about letting the explorer sift through the mixed bundles to which he appeared indifferent, he was, on the other hand, eager to shield the regular bundles from Stein:

> The secret hope of diverting by their sacrifice my attention from the precious rolls of Chinese canonical texts or 'Ching' [jing 經] made him now more assiduously grope for and hand out bundles of what he evidently classed under the head of miscellaneous rubbish.[94]

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[89] Stein, *Serindia*, 1921: p. 808.

[90] Stein, ibid.: p. 809.

[91] Stein, *Serindia*, 1921: p. 814.

[92] The Bodleian Libraries Oxford, typed transcript of Stein's field diaries, entry for 23 May 1907, MSS Stein 204: ff. 307–8.

[93] Stein, *Ruins of Desert Cathay*, 1912: p. 182.

[94] Stein, *Ruins of Desert Cathay*, 1912: pp. 178–9.

Thanks to Jiang's persuasion, Wang also consented to let them remove the items that they were putting aside, provided that they exercised the utmost discretion and acted in secret:[95]

> The Tao-shih [Daoshi] had summoned up the courage to fall in with my wishes, on the solemn condition that nobody besides us three was to get the slightest inkling of what was being transacted, and that as long as I kept Chinese soil the origin of these 'finds' was not to be revealed to any living being.[96]

However, Wang Yuanlu did not want to be seen outside of his quarters at night, so Jiang Xiaowan took upon himself to be the courier. He carried the documents back to the explorer's tent, when everybody else was asleep, so as not to alert anyone.[97] We can thus see clearly that Wang remained, as much as he could, in control of the situation and made sure that the transaction was done on his terms.

Stein spent five days tirelessly working his way through the 'miscellaneous' bundles that Wang brought him. He gathered items that he thought of special interest. By this, he meant "everything that possessed artistic or archaeological value, and whatever manuscripts in Indian or Central Asian languages could be traced."[98] The explorer was surprised and delighted as Wang "raised no objection when [he] put aside rapidly 'for closer inspection' the best of the pictures on silk, linen, and paper I could lay my hands on […]."[99] Much to his joy, he managed to handpick some banners, paintings, and several manuscripts in Brahmi, Sanskrit, and Uyghur, which were written in a variety of formats. During his rushed survey of the mixed bundles, he

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[95] Stein, *Serindia*, 1921: p. 813.

[96] Stein, *Ruins of Desert Cathay*, 1912: p. 181.

[97] Stein, *Serindia*, 1921: p. 813; Stein, *Ruins of Desert Cathay*, 1912: p. 181.

[98] Confidential report by Stein concerning the cache of ancient manuscripts at Dunhuang, British Museum archives, CE 32/23/16/2.

[99] Stein, *Serindia*, 1921: p. 812.

also extracted any of the secular texts in Chinese that could be detected, as well as drawings and woodblock prints that he came across.[100]

Despite the amazing 'finds' he had made already, Stein was still intent on accessing the "rampart" of regular manuscript bundles "rising against the walls of the chapel":

> I was naturally anxious to have these, too, cleared out in order to be able to search them rapidly, but felt scarcely surprised when this proved a troublesome undertaking in more than one sense. We had so far succeeded in overcoming the Tao-shih [Daoshi]'s relapses into timorous contrariness by discreet diplomacy and judiciously administered doses of silver. But now, when faced by the heavy labour of clearing out the whole chamber and by the increased risk of exposure thus involved, the priest became distinctly refractory.[101]

Nevertheless, Wang Yuanlu overcame his hesitations and started removing the regular bundles with the help of an assistant.[102] As hinted in Stein's diaries, he was probably swayed by the prospect of a donation:

> During morning, Wang opened question as to donation for temple. Took up the theme in order to introduce question of purchase. No definite offer could be made until I had seen the full extent of the collection. So Wang, his helpmate and Sieh [Shiye] slaved all the afternoon in clearing out bundles of MSS. From cella.[103]

By nightfall on 27 May 1907, "the whole of the regular 'library bundles' [had been] taken out and transferred to neat rows, mainly in the spacious cella of the temple [Cave 16]"

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[100] The Bodleian Libraries Oxford, typed transcript of Stein's field diaries, entries for 23 to 27 May 1907, MSS Stein 204: ff. 307–315.

[101] Stein, *Serindia*, 1921: p. 822.

[102] Stein, *Serindia*, 1921: p. 822.

[103] The Bodleian Libraries Oxford, typed transcript of Stein's field diaries, entry for 27 May 1907, MSS Stein 204: ff. 315.

(figure 3).[104] Stein and Jiang Xiaowan tried to "pick out as well as time would permit", without even slowing down to unfold any of the manuscript rolls or look on their backs.[105] They worried that any thorough search might have adverse effects on Wang Yuanlu, who was uneasy about them going through material that he quite clearly highly valued. The Chinese sutras "to which alone he seemed to attach any real value" were particularly sensitive.[106] The operation also yielded a pleasant surprise, for several large miscellaneous bundles, placed by Wang Yuanlu at the very bottom, were now revealed. As mentioned previously, they were providing a stable foundation to the 'regular' bundles. They contained a considerable number of exquisite silk paintings and some beautiful textile pieces that Stein put aside as part of his 'selections'.[107]

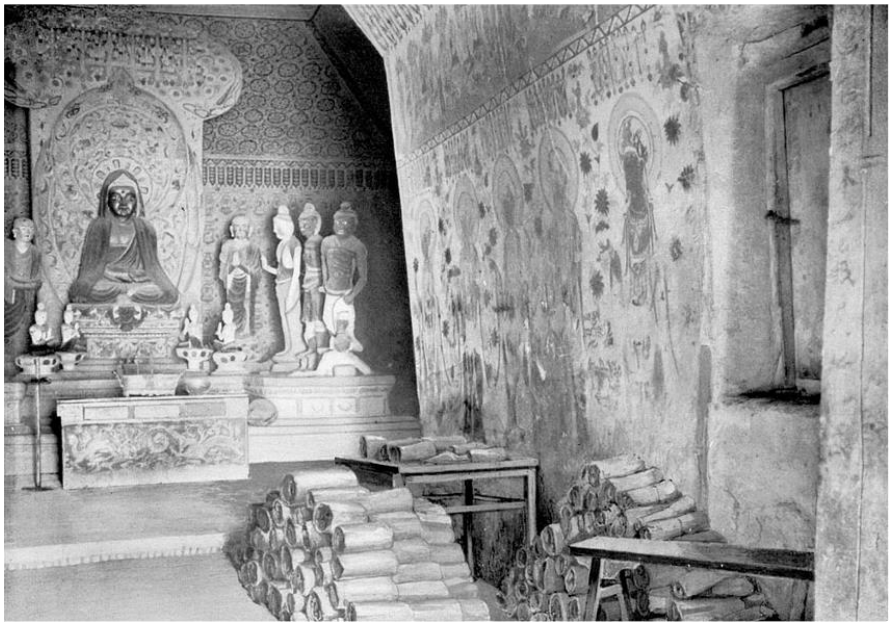


Figure 3, Photograph taken by Stein showing piled up manuscript bundles and tables outside of Cave 17. The negative was modified to recreate this scene, as the original photograph was double exposed.

[104] Stein, ibid.: p. 823.

[105] Stein, *Serindia*, 1921: p. 823.

[106] Stein, *Ruins of Desert Cathay*, 1912: p. 191.

[107] Stein, *Serindia*, 1921: pp. 823–824. The Bodleian Libraries Oxford, typed transcript of Stein's field diaries, entry for 2 May 1907, MSS Stein 204: ff. 317–8.

Having grown increasingly tense, Wang was keen to end his proceedings with the explorer and "came to business":

> While asking for a substantial subscription to his temple, he yet protested that any cession of sacred texts or 'Chings [jing 經]' and among these he classed all Chinese manuscript rolls, whatever their contents might be—was impossible.[108]

Stein decided to make an attempt for the acquisition of the whole of the hoard, but he was faced with categorical refusal from Wang Yuanlu. His insistence only made the situation worse. Stein reported that during their transaction, Wang had been constantly "vacillat[ing] between fears about his saintly reputation and a shrewd grasp of the advantages to be attained for his cherished task by accommodating [him] with regard to useless old things."[109] There was more behind his reluctance than this. In his diaries, Stein wrote that Wang Yuanlu raised difficulties "about [the] consent of donors."[110] Further expanding on this in his published accounts, he explained Wang was anxious that any deficiency in the piles of 'library bundles' would be noticed by his lay patrons and "lead to the loss of the position which he had built up for himself in the district by the pious labours of eight years and to the destruction of his life's task."[111] Wang Yuanlu told Stein that his sponsors "had as much right to control [these sacred objects] as he had" and insisted that he needed to consult them before making any further decision.[112]

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[108] Stein, *Serindia*, 1921: p. 823.

[109] Stein, *Serindia*, p. 813.

[110] The Bodleian Libraries Oxford, typed transcript of Stein's field diaries, entry for 23 May 1907, MSS Stein 204: ff. 316.

[111] Stein, *Serindia*, 1921: p. 824.

[112] Stein, *Ibid*, 1921: p. 824.

In his published accounts, Stein recounted how he went to skim through the regular bundles in search for more interesting materials the next day and realised that Wang Yuanlu had shifted all the bundles back into Cave 17 overnight. He then further reported how the two of them had nevertheless managed to reach a compromise assuring him "fifty well-preserved bundles of Chinese text rolls and five of Tibetan ones, besides all [his] previous selections from the miscellaneous bundles."[113] His personal diary tells another story. In fact, Wang Yuanlu had left behind between 30 and 40 less well-preserved bundles and Stein only obtained half of the finally selected bundles from the small cave. [114] Since the bundles were now safely back into their original place of deposit, it is probable that Wang Yuanlu chose, yet again, which ones he felt it would be acceptable to part with. As soon as the heavy load of Chinese and Tibetan manuscripts was quietly transferred inside sacks to Stein's storeroom, Wang went begging for alms in Dunhuang. Considering what he had said to Stein about the right of his patrons to decide on the fate of the manuscripts, he could have taken this opportunity to ask them if they would be supportive of his transaction with Stein. Stein's report did state that upon coming back from town, a week later, Wang seemed "reassured that the secret had not been discovered, and that his spiritual influence, such as it was, had suffered no diminution."[115]

Wang Yuanlu, who had perhaps received his sponsors' approval, was certainly sufficiently emboldened to let Stein purchase 20 regular bundles of manuscripts, with additional selections from the 'mixed' bundles. The explorer left the Mogao Caves on 12 June 1907, with seven cases crammed with the manuscript acquisitions and five cases containing the paintings, embroideries, and other items:

[113] Stein, *Serindia*, 1912: p. 193.

[114] Bodleian Libraries Oxford, entry for 29 May 1907, MSS 204: f. 319.

[115] Stein, *Serindia*, 1921: p. 825.

> I had the satisfaction of seeing that the shy Tao-shih [Daoshi], honest in his own way, now breathed freely again. It seemed almost as if in a dim way he recognized that it was a pious act on his part to let me rescue for Western scholarship as much as circumstances would permit of those ancient Buddhist relics which local ignorance would allow to lie here neglected or to be lost in the end. When I finally took my departure from the 'Halls of the Thousand Buddhas', his quaint, sharp-cut face had resumed its customary expression of shy but self-contented serenity. We parted in fullest amity.[116]

Stein's interpretation of the reasons behind Wang's calmness and better disposition are misleading. To the latter, the 'pious act' was the sale of the cave's contents to fund the ongoing renovation work which occupied him; and since Wang and other monks were making use of the manuscripts and paintings for religious purposes, Wang would not have been worried about their 'neglect'. Wang had been conflicted throughout his negotiations with Aurel Stein and was undoubtedly relieved to see him go.

The second phase of Stein's acquisitions happened four months later, when he stopped at Anxi to get the cases of antiquities that he had left in the Magistrate's office on his way back from Jiuquan. He sent through a messenger a written proposal to enquire about making further 'selections' from Cave 17, which was "met with a cautious response."[117] In his answer, received on 27 September 1907, Wang Yuanlu clearly stated how much money he expected per 100 bundles, already setting the tone of the transaction.[118] To avoid raising suspicions, Stein stayed behind and entrusted his Chinese secretary to the Mogao Caves to negotiate on

[116] Stein, *Serindia*, 1921: p. 825.

[117] Stein, *Ruins of Desert Cathay*, vol. 2, 1912: p. 339.

[118] The Bodleian Libraries Oxford, typed transcript of Stein's field diaries from December 1906 to August 1908, entry for 27 September 1907, MSS Stein 205: f. 90.

his behalf with Wang Yuanlu.[119] Jiang Xiaowan left for the Mogao Caves on 29 September with 600 Taels, the plan being for him to reach the site by 2 October and to be back by 6 October at the latest.[120] In the evening of 4 October 1907, the convoy returned with four camels heavily laden with more manuscripts. They had marched by night not to draw attention.[121] In his personal narrative, Stein recounted that the "secret mission" was a resounding success:

> How he had managed to secure the timorous Taoist monk, and to induce him for a very reasonable recompense to hand out at night over two hundred additional bundles of Chinese texts, was quite a dramatic story. The whole was managed most discreetly.[122]

The explorer's field diary offers some slightly different insights. When Jiang had reached the caves on 1 October 1907, Wang was away and his "famulus" had to go on a donkey to fetch him. Despite Jiang's efforts, Wang Yuanlu refused to reduce his price and did not agree to further sale. He proved particularly opposed to parting with some of the Tibetan manuscripts, in which group of lamas had expressed an interest:

> It appears Tib.[etan] Mss. are to be taken over by some 6–9 red-robed Tib.[etan] monks who wish to keep them in a separate shrine. These men made Tao-shih [Daoshi] nervous. 200 bundles were taken out from dark hole without previous selection; but [Jiang Siye] says he rejected 'lan-di' ones. Packing done hurriedly within cave and sacks put on *shotas* within.[123]

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[119] Stein, *Ruins of Desert Cathay*, vol. 2, 1912: p. 339.

[120] The Bodleian Libraries Oxford, typed transcript of Stein's field diaries from December 1906 to August 1908, entry for 29 September 1907, MSS Stein 205: f. 91.

[121] The Bodleian Libraries Oxford, typed transcript of Stein's field diaries from December 1906 to August 1908, entry for 5 October 1907, MSS Stein 205/94.

[122] Stein, *Ruins of Desert Cathay*, vol. 2, 1912: p. 339.

[123] The Bodleian Libraries Oxford, typed transcript of Stein's field diaries from December 1906 to August 1908, entry for 5 October 1907, MSS Stein 205: f. 95.

This passage demonstrates again that Wang was guiding the selection process. It also suggests that the local Buddhist community may have had some influence over the negotiations surrounding the sale of the Cave 17's contents, as Wang appeared to prioritise the monks' interests in this instance. Wang Yuanlu did end up ceding a large share of Chinese and Tibetan manuscripts but was driving the transaction at every stage. The fact that Jiang Xiaowan rejected several of the "lan-di" (spoiled or decayed) bundles might also indicate that Wang Yuanlu was also trying to cede the manuscripts that he prized the least.[124] When picking up gifts for officials, Wang had chosen particularly fine manuscripts, with beautiful handwriting and in excellent condition. In contradistinction, most of the scrolls he agreed to sell to Jiang would have been made of coarser paper, copied by scribes with poorer calligraphy, incomplete or in a mediocre to bad state of preservation. Upon leaving Dunhuang in mid-June 1907, Stein had taken with him "over 90 bundles of such manuscripts, containing about 1,200 separate texts in rolls or "Pothis." This new tranche of materials, which must have come from the piles of regular bundles, was even more significant than the previous one: it amounted to 230 of the regular bundles and "raised the number of texts to close on 4,000."[125]

When Stein first met Wang, he quickly understood that the preservation of the Mogao Caves complex was key to him. He saw in his pious endeavours a potentially powerful motivation to sell the contents of Cave 17, while Wang saw in Stein an opportunity to get money for the upkeep of the site. But throughout the transactions that ensued, Wang Yuanlu proved nervous

[124] The author would like to thank their two anonymous reviewers for suggesting that "lan-di" might be Stein's transcription for 爛的, meaning 'rotten', 'decayed' or 'ragged.' This term would have denoted manuscript scraps considered of low value.

[125] British Museum Central Archives, CE 32/23/16/2.

and in two minds. He was especially averse to parting with the 'regular' bundles of Buddhist sutras, including Tibetan manuscripts. As we have seen, this was due to the high value that the local religious community assigned to these parts of the cave's contents. Wang set the conditions for their 'exchange': he picked the bundles for Stein's examination and when Jiang returned on his own later; he agreed where Stein and Jiang should carry their work, and he stipulated that the 'selections' should be transferred at night in the greatest secrecy.

Wang Yuanlu and Paul Pelliot

Less than a year after Stein, on 12 February 1908, Paul Pelliot arrived at Dunhuang, where he stayed until the beginning of June 1908. During his sojourn in Urumqi at the end of 1907, he had heard of the newly found repository at the Mogao Caves complex and had been shown an eighth-century manuscript from Cave 17.[126] This had made him even more eager to reach the Thousand Buddha Caves, which were already on his itinerary when he left France. Once there, Pelliot also purchased a sizeable portion of the cave's contents from Wang Yuanlu. Stein may have been the first Western explorer to see the newly discovered cache, but I would argue that Pelliot's luck was to have come in second place. It may have resulted in him securing some of the 'rarest' pieces.

By the time Pelliot came to the Mogao Caves, Wang had had several months to see whether there were any repercussions to selling crates-worth of materials from the small cave

[126] Pelliot, Paul. "Trois Ans dans la Haute Asie. Conférence de M. Paul Pelliot au Grand Amphithéâtre de la Sorbonne, le 10 décembre 1909." Extrait du *Bulletin du Comité de l'Asie Française* (Janvier 1910) (Paris: Comité de l'Asie Française, 1910): p. 13. The article has been digitised and is available on Toyo Bunko, http://dsr.nii.ac.jp/toyobunko/VIII-5-B2-12/, doi: 10.20676/00000241.

to Stein. The benefits must have outweighed the negatives for he was ready to engage in another such transaction with Pelliot. According to the French sinologist:

> Mr. Stein had worked in the cave for three days, and officially bought a certain number of manuscripts, with the knowledge of the local mandarin; the monk added that our colleague [Stein] had also personally left him a sum, which he said was plump, to get more [manuscripts]. A word to the wise; I knew for certain the procedure to adopt myself.[127]

There is no evidence that Wang Yuanlu ever made any sort of agreement with the local official – if anything, this is at odds with the discretion that Stein was asked to use during their interactions. Could this have been a lie meant to put Pelliot at ease and convince him to engage in a financial deal with Wang?

While Wang Yuanlu had been opposed to giving Stein full access to the small repository and had insisted on handing him over pre-selected bundles of materials, he showed no such resistance when the Frenchman came. Interestingly, Wang did not seem concerned anymore about people finding out what Pelliot was up to. He had asked Stein and Jiang to work in a screened room during the day and to remove materials 'for further examination' (knowing what this implied) at night, but Pelliot never mentioned any stipulations of this kind. For three weeks, from 3 March 1908 onwards, Pelliot used the small space vacated by the items taken by Stein to squat inside the niche, going through as many items as he could. He was amazed to find many of the bundles still intact and sewn up.[128] During the first ten days of his stay, he managed to freely check up to 1000 scrolls per day.[129] A photograph shows him crouching in Cave 17, examining manuscripts by candlelight, with piles of materials behind him.

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[127] Translated by the author. Pelliot, "Une bibliothèque médiévale retrouvée au Kan-sou", *Bulletin de l'École Française d'Extrême Orient* 8 (1908): p. 505.

[128] Pelliot, "Une bibliothèque médiévale" (1908): pp. 506–7.

[129] Pelliot, ibid.: p. 505.

With regards to the manuscripts, several of Pelliot's selection criteria were actually similar to Stein's. He too prioritised the scrolls written in languages such as Uyghur or Brahmi:

> My ignorance simplified the choice of non-Chinese documents. I distinguish many letters and their alphabet, but the meaning escapes me; to leave nothing interesting behind, I acquired everything.[130]

Pelliot tried to acquire the bulk of the remaining Tibetan documents, putting aside "about five hundred kilos of manuscripts dating back to the first four centuries of Tibetan Buddhism."[131] He also focused his attention on the Chinese manuscripts with dated colophons, as well as the non-Buddhist texts and documents with a historical interest. His mastery of Classical Chinese allowed him to better sort through materials in this language, including non-canonical Buddhist texts. Unlike Stein, who had insisted on acquiring the 'regular' or 'library' bundles, Pelliot was not really interested in them. For instance, he deliberately discarded the Chinese copies of the *Lotus Sutra* and of the *Nirvana Sutra*.[132] This might be why he did not encounter the same resistance from Wang Yuanlu, who valued these canonical sutra scrolls most highly.

Overall, Wang did not object to Pelliot's selections, but he did not let him acquire everything either. Pelliot was very keen to have the huge Tibetan *pothi* stacked in perfect order in a corner of the cave that, as we mentioned earlier, Wang Yuanlu identified as a form of Kanjur or Tibetan Buddhist canon.[133] Wang Yuanlu explained that a Mongol prince from Qaidam or Tsaidam, who travelled to the Mogao Caves every year, had got into the habit of consulting them each time. He thus refused to part with these manuscripts, to avoid upsetting

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[130] Pelliot, "Une bibliothèque médiévale", (1908): p. 508.

[131] Pelliot, "Une bibliothèque médiévale", (1908): p. 507.

[132] Pelliot, Ibid.

[133] Lalou, "Les manuscrits tibétains des grandes prajñapāpāramitā trouvés à Touen-houang", in *Silver Jubilee Volume of the Zinbun-Kagaku-Kenkyusyo*, 1954: p. 257.

the regular visitor.[134] Despite protracted negotiations, Wang only conceded him the sale of three volumes.[135] In an attempt to divert the Sinologist's attention and safeguard these Tibetan copies of the *Perfection of Wisdom Sutra*, Wang Yuanlu offered Pelliot several paintings. He claimed that they were the best in his opinion and that he had put them aside a long time ago.[136] Stein was most probably right in thinking that Wang Yuanlu had handed him what he considered to be 'rubbish' during his visit in 1907,[137] because Wang had obviously held onto the items he deemed more important.

In August–September of 1909, Pelliot travelled to Beijing to buy books for the Bibliothèque nationale de France. He had with him a small selection of Dunhuang manuscripts, which several scholars came to examine and photograph. They formed an association to reproduce and publish the most important texts.[138] This marked a turning point, as Chinese scholars became aware of the value of Cave 17's contents. They petitioned the Qing Ministry of Education, which ordered in 1910 that the remaining manuscripts be sent to Beijing for safekeeping. Unfortunately, there were several instances of theft and loss during their transfer to the capital.[139]

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[134] Pelliot, "Une bibliothèque médiévale retrouvée au Kan-sou", 1908: p. 507.

[135] In his travel diaries, Pelliot said on 12 May 1908 that he only managed to buy one of these books; see Pelliot, *Carnets de Route, 1906-1908*, 2008: p. 294. However, the post-scriptum to an article published the same year indicates that he secured three volumes; see Pelliot, "Une bibliothèque médiévale retrouvée au Kan-sou", 1908: p. 529, n.1.

[136] Pelliot, *Carnets de Route*, 2008: p. 136.

[137] See full quote earlier in the article; Stein, *Ruins of Desert Cathay*, 1912: pp. 178–9.

[138] Pelliot, Paul. "Trois Ans dans la Haute Asie," (Janvier 1910): p. 15.

[139] Rong Xinjiang, *Eighteen Lectures on Dunhuang*, 2013: p. 106.

Wang Yuanlu's attitude was vastly different during Pelliot's visit in 1908. Although it is often said that Pelliot got better access thanks to his excellent Chinese, there are reasons to believe that there was more to it. By then, Wang had set his own boundaries in terms of what could and could not be sold, possibly in accord with his lay patrons and the local monastic community. Furthermore, unlike Stein who insisted on purchasing materials from the regular bundles, Pelliot was not interested in collecting Buddhist canonical texts, which may have resulted in less tension in his dealings with Wang.

Stein's Second visit to Dunhuang

As we have just seen, most of Cave 17's remaining manuscripts were transferred to Beijing in 1910. In the letter written on red paper mentioned in the first part of this article, Wang Yuanlu complained that he did not receive the amount of money that he had been promised for his restoration work. He also mentioned 'donating' thousands of scrolls to Stein and Pelliot, although he was careful to use a turn of phrase emphasizing the piety of this act.[140] This certainly shows that Wang did not try to hide that he had given a large number of items to the two foreigners, even if he did not explain that he did so against payment. What Wang Yuanlu kept quiet is that he had managed to secrete away hundreds of items. In 1912, Wang sold several hundreds of manuscripts from his stash to Tachibana Zuichō 橘瑞超 (1890–1968) and Yoshikawa Koichirō 吉川小一郎 (1885–1978) of the third Ōtani expedition (1910–1914).

[140] Shuchen Wang, "Atoms & Bits of Cultural Heritage: The Use of Dunhuang Collections in Knowledge Making, Nation Building, Museum Diplomacy, Cultural Tourism and Digital Economy", PhD thesis, Aalto University, 2019: p. 57, footnote 15. Last accessed 30/07/2024: https://urn.fi/URN:ISBN:978-952-60-8685-9.

Most were "Tang sutras."[141] Yoshikawa returned to Dunhuang on his own in 1914 and purchased more manuscripts.[142] A large proportion of these were Tibetan copies of the *Aparamitayus Sutra*, which would presumably have been in the regular 'library' bundles.[143]

When Stein stopped at Dunhuang again in 1914, in the course of his third Central Asian expedition (1913–1916), Wang was still in possession of manuscripts from Cave 17. Wang Yuanlu welcomed Stein to town and cordially invited him to the Mogao Caves, hinting at the fact that his own store of ancient manuscripts had not been completely depleted yet.[144] According to Stein, Wang also told him "with a bitterness only too justified", that he had received none of the large sum assigned by the Central Government as compensation for the removal of the manuscripts.[145] The money had vanished on the way, "duly absorbed in transit through various offices,"[146] and he regretted "not having previously had the courage and wisdom to accept the big offer that [Stein] had made through Jiang Siye for the whole collection

[141] The diaries of Yoshikawa Koichirō reveal that they bought manuscripts from people other than Wang Yuanlu, including a farm labourer and a Chinese merchant. See Ueyama Daishun, "How I came to be convinced that the Ōtani collection contains forged manuscripts", in Whitfield, Susan (ed.), Dunhuang Manuscripts Forgeries, 2002: pp. 316–320.

[142] Hao Chunwen, *Dunhuang Manuscripts: An Introduction to Texts from the Silk Road*, translated by Stephen Teiser, 2020: p. 51.

[143] Shang Lin 尚林, Fang Guangchang 方廣錩 and Rong Xinjiang, *Zhongguo suocang Dagu shoujipin gaikuang: Tebie yi Dunhuang xiejing wei zhongxin* 中國所藏集品概況—特別以敦煌寫經為中心, Kyoto: Ryūkoku daigaku Saiiki bunka kenkyūkai, 1991.

[144] Stein, *Innermost Asia*, 1928: p. 356.

[145] Stein, *Innermost Asia*, 1928: p. 355.

[146] Stein, *On Ancient Central-Asian Tracks*, 1933: p. 210.

en bloc."[147] According to Stein, Wang Yuanlu's patrons felt the same and were most probably informed that Wang had disobeyed official orders and hidden textual materials from Cave 17:

> His devout clientèle among the Tun-huang population, seeing how well he had laid out the sums received, first from myself and then from Pei Ta jên, i.e. M. Pelliot, in building new gaudy chapels and a large, comfortable hospice, seemed to agree in sharing his feelings. They, no doubt, fully approved too of the shrewd precaution which the honest Taoist monk had taken against the official spoliation of the temple becoming too complete.[148]

Stein made his way to the site on 2 April 1914. The following day, he got confirmation that Wang had indeed put away a "nest-egg" of Chinese manuscripts.[149] Wang showed him two large boxes crammed with sutra rolls:

> By the careful appearance of their writing and the superior quality of the paper it was easy to recognize that the specimens I was able to rapidly examine belonged to that great stock of canonical texts, mostly Buddhist and dating from Tang times, with which Wang Tao-shih [Daoshi], under the influence of quasi-religious scruples, had in 1907 been least willing to part.[150]

Almost all these scrolls, Stein noted, were large and in remarkably good condition.[151] Wang had thus strived to retain the Buddhist sutras made of fine paper that were big or complete and well preserved. These characteristics, clearly important to him, were ones shared by the manuscripts that he had, as early as 1900, earmarked as gifts for Gansu officials. Moreover,

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[147] Stein, *On Ancient Central-Asian Tracks*, 1933: p. 211.

[148] Stein, Serindia, 1921: p. 830.

[149] Stein, *On Ancient Central-Asian Tracks*, 1933: p. 211.

[150] Stein, *Innermost Asia*, 1928: p. 358.

[151] Stein, *Innermost Asia*, 1928: p. 358.

they probably came from the 'regular' bundles that Wang had been particularly disinclined to sell during Stein's first visit.

Stein admitted being under no illusion as to their scholarly significance and did not, this time, "reasonably hope for any finds of outstanding importance."[152] In all likelihood, most of these manuscripts had been passed through Pelliot's expert hands, who would have selected "all remains of non-Chinese texts that he could trace and those among the Chinese texts of which the special interest was once apparent."[153] Frustratingly for Stein, however, Wang Yuanlu now demanded a much higher 'donation' than he had when he first visited the Mogao Caves. Not only had Wang learned from his subsequent transactions with other explorers, but he also wanted appropriate compensation for these scrolls that he conceived to be of special value:

> [...] his shrewd sense of business had been awakened by the payments received from subsequent visitors to a keener comprehension of the money value of what he retained. He consequently held out at first for a price per roll which, being about four times as much as that paid on the occasion of [Jiang Shiye 師爺]'s big haul of October, 1907, seemed distinctly too high. No doubt Wang's estimate was greatly influenced by the fact that the rolls he was now prepared to part with were almost all large ones and particularly well preserved.[154]

In the end, Stein purchased 570 Buddhist manuscripts, filling a total of five cases, "each as large as a pony could conveniently carry."[155] In addition, to seal their deal, Wang presented him with a miscellaneous collection of relief stucco plaques that he had supposedly found in

[152] Stein, *Innermost Asia*, 1928: p. 358.

[153] Stein, *Innermost Asia*, 1928: p. 358.

[154] Stein, *Innermost Asia*, 1928: p. 358.

[155] Stein, *Innermost Asia*, 1928: p. 358.

another one of the Mogao caves.[156] Once again, Wang Yuanlu determined what Stein was eventually able to acquire: items that mostly belonged to the Chinese Buddhist canon, including some as early as the fifth and sixth centuries.

During Stein's second visit, Wang showed him his accounts, as well as the various new structures that had sprouted in the past seven years, largely thanks to the payment made in 1907 in exchange for his 'selections'. Right opposite Cave 16 and Cave 17 now stood a guest-house, a series of shrines and a few facilities that "attested the little priest's single-minded ambition to restore, according to his lights, the glory and popular attractions of the ancient sacred site."[157] Several wall paintings and stucco sculptures had also been restored. Elsewhere, much work had been done to remove the drift sand blocking the entrance to the lower-level caves, and to render the upper-level caves accessible by "cutting passages from one cave-shrine to another right through the rock wall separating them."[158] These controversial interventions, which could not have been carried out by Wang on his own, are further proof that the Thousand Buddha Caves were an active place of worship, very much anchored in the local religious life.

As Stein left with his new acquisitions, he could not help but wonder "whether the contents of the two big boxes of manuscripts which Wang Tao-shih [Daoshi] kept in his store-room really represented the whole of the reserve he had managed to retain."[159] There is no way to prove if his suspicions were right. In August 1914, the Russian Orientalist and Buddhist scholar Sergey Oldenburg (1863–1934), who was leading his second Russian Turkestan expedition (1914–15), travelled to Dunhuang. His team undertook the systematic study and

[156] Stein, *Innermost Asia*, 1928: p. 359.

[157] Stein, *Innermost Asia*, 1928: p. 357.

[158] Stein, *Innermost Asia*, 1928: p. 360.

[159] Stein, *Innermost Asia*, 1928: p. 359.

reproduction of the pictorial and sculptural remains of the Mogao Caves, compiling an account of all caves, reproducing floor plans, taking photographs and making copies of some murals. They did gather 19,000 Dunhuang manuscripts, mostly fragments, as well as over 350 paintings. These materials appear to have been acquired during the examination of other caves at the site, rather than Cave 17.[160]

Most of the remaining contents of Cave 17 had been removed for several years by the time Stein returned to Dunhuang in 1914. However, the explorer managed to secure another 600 fine Buddhist scrolls from Wang Yuanlu, who still possessed manuscripts from the small cache. This time, Wang who had learnt from his dealings with Pelliot and the members of the Ōtani expedition, was determined to secure as much profit as possible to keep funding his restoration work. The manuscripts that Stein acquired on this occasion now also form part of the Dunhuang corpus at the British Library. Again, he could only choose from the materials that were made available to him, and, in that sense, Wang played a determining role in shaping the collection that the explorer was gathering.

[160] For an overview, see Hao Chunwen, *Dunhuang Manuscripts*, 2020: 54–56. For more details, refer to Popova, Irina F., "S.F. Oldenburg's Second Russian Turkestan Expedition (1914–1915)", pp. 158–175. http://www.orientalstudies.ru/rus/images/pdf/a_popova_2008d.pdf. In addition to the items collected in 1914–15, several Dunhuang manuscripts acquired from an unknown source had been transferred to St Petersburg in 1911. See Alexander Zorin, "The Collection of Dunhuang Tibetan Texts Kept at the IOM RAS", Institute of Oriental Manuscripts, RAS, St. Petersburg, 2012: pp. 365–367; http://www.orientalstudies.ru/rus/images/pdf/a_zorin_2012_b.pdf.

Conclusion

Wang Yuanlu, the man whose pious restoration work led to one of the most astonishing discoveries of the twentieth century, is a fascinating character. The present article attempts to provide a more nuanced understanding of him by examining his relationship to the Mogao Caves and their wider ecosystem, especially the community of local Buddhist monks and the lay donors that funded his enterprises, by looking at the way he drove the transactions with Stein during his first visit in 1907 and, finally by studying the subsequent dispersal of Cave 17's contents and the acquisitions made by Stein when he returned to the site in 1914. We argue here that Wang is not so much an 'obscure' as an 'obscured' figure.

When taking a closer look at Aurel Stein's detailed writings as well as other sources, there are many hints of a much more complex personality. They certainly belie the simplistic image of a "quaint priest, with [a] curious mixture of pious zeal, naïve ignorance, and astute tenacity of purpose,"[161] who was swayed to sell thousands of manuscripts, painting and other artefacts from Cave 17 because of the admiration he and Stein had in common for the monk Xuanzang or because he believed that he would "acquire spiritual merit by letting [Stein] take back to the old home of Buddhism some of the ancient manuscripts which chance had placed in his keeping."[162] Wang had much more agency than he usually is credited for, but he should not be reduced to a thief or even a shrewd businessman, who saw the contents of Cave 17 as mere commodities. According to Justin Jacobs, he "sought to control access to his 'goods,'

[161] Stein, *Ruins of Desert Cathay*, 1912: p. 169.

[162] Stein, *Ruins of Desert Cathay*, 1912: p. 170.

carefully manage his 'stock,' and 'sell' them on his own terms."[163] This is not a completely fair characterisation of his actions, and most importantly, of the true motivation(s) behind them.

Wang Yuanlu, who took upon himself to act as the guardian of the Mogao Caves when he arrived at the site and joined in the restoration efforts already initiated before his time, can also be considered the first 'curator' or 'keeper' of Cave 17 and its contents. He did alert the authorities of the existence of the newly found hoard and, having been left in charge of preserving the collection, protected it by installing a door with a lock and re-organised the room according to an arrangement that he deemed more suitable. Stein's accounts misrepresent Wang as unaware of the nature of the cave's contents, which is far from the truth. Wang Yuanlu collaborated closely with resident Buddhist monks, relying on their expertise to identify some materials, and lending them items for ritual purposes. He also handpicked fine specimens that he presented as gifts to Gansu officials. Finally, having completely emptied and re-stacked Cave 17, he would have had a good grasp of the cache's contents. He is the only individual who ever had an overall picture of what it contained and how the materials were originally deposited. This insider knowledge came in handy in his negotiations with Stein.

Equally important is the role Wang Yuanlu played in shaping the now so-called Dunhuang Stein collection. Throughout his transactions with Aurel Stein, Wang was concerned to control of the situation, setting up the conditions for the exchange. When Stein first visited the Thousand Buddha Caves in 1907, he was not allowed to freely search for materials in the repository. He had to rely on Wang's choice of bundles, from which to make selections. At all times, Stein and Jiang Xiaowan had to act in quasi-secrecy, so as not to arouse suspicions. Wang Yuanlu was particularly reluctant when it came to the Buddhist canonical texts forming the bulk of the 'regular bundles,' which he had safely sandwiched between a bottom and top

[163] Justin Jacobs, *The Compensations of Plunder*, 2020: p. 97.

layer of 'miscellaneous' bundles. He tried to distract the explorer by supplying bundle after bundle of miscellaneous materials that he considered to be 'rubbish' or almost worthless, i.e. the paintings, drawings, printed documents, and texts in central Asian languages. This is how the wonderful embroidery of the Buddha at the Vultures Peak or the printed copy of the Diamond Sutra dated to 868 ended up in the United Kingdom.[164] Stein nevertheless secured a substantial number of 'regular' bundles, in 1907 and then again when he returned to the Mogao Caves in 1914. This is why the British Library's Stein collection contains many manuscript copies of the same scripture, like the *Lotus Sutra* or the *Diamond Sutra* in Chinese.

Ultimately, Wang Yuanlu made a judgement call between the relative importance of the Mogao Caves site as a whole versus that of Cave 17's contents. Enabling repair works to what had been a thriving Buddhist pilgrimage centre from the fourth to the fourteenth centuries was a work of piety to which he devoted his entire life, channelling all the money he collected through his begging tours and then the sale of Dunhuang manuscripts towards clearing off the sand obstructing the caves, repairing statues and paintings and restoring shrines around the site. Not only was his decision made from the perspective of living practice, as opposed to that of scholarship, it was also made collectively. Although Wang obviously wanted to avoid drawing attention to his transaction with Stein, it seems likely that the Buddhist monks established at the site would have been in the know. In addition, Wang Yuanlu consulted the donors supporting his initiatives, as he told Stein he was keen to do, facilitating more open transactions with Pelliot and other explorers afterwards. The implication here is that he acted with the accord and on behalf of the small religious community that he belonged to. It seems that Wang's dealings with Stein, Pelliot and others did not diminish the esteem in which he was held by this

[164] They are now respectively held at the British Museum and British Library.

community, for, when he died in 1931, his disciples obtained permission from local authorities to erect a stupa in his honour opposite the caves.[165]

[165] Rong, *Eighteen Lectures on Dunhuang*, 2013: p. 107.